

GRAINGUARD · DESIGN PRECIS

GrainGuard design precis

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DOCUMENT CONTROL

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Project TRL	TRL 3 Proof of concept		
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REVISION HISTORY

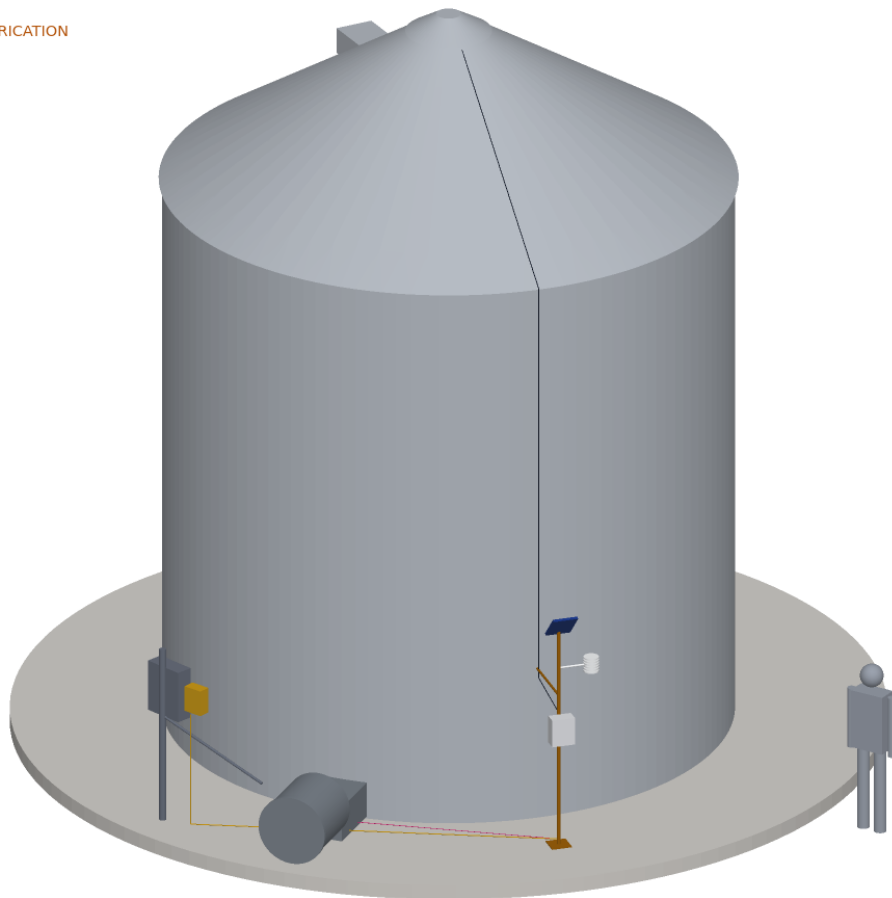
Version	Date	Author	Change
0.4	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Recommendations accepted by Amish (DDR-002). Plenum probe moved into the base kit; kit \$247.00 to \$256.50 with the overrun accepted; R4 met; drawing GGD-DWG-001 Rev P2 and media refreshed
0.3	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	TRL 3 decisions (GGD-DDR-001) recorded; design choices no longer proposed; numbers checked against GGD-CAL-001; pod split, smaller enclosure, 3 mA relay input, 15.0 V charge clamp, plenum probe option; model, drawing GGD-DWG-001 and media refreshed
0.2	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Populate to TRL 2 (architecture, control rule, first-order numbers, safety, media)
0.1	2026-09-24	Amish Chadha	Initial scaffold

GrainGuard design precis

GrainGuard hangs one cable of six temperature and humidity pods down the center of an existing grain bin, measures the outside air beside the bin, and switches the existing aeration fan through a small relay kit only when the air entering the grain will cool it or dry it without rewetting it. A solar-powered 12 V controller on a mast by the bin makes the decision and reports to a receiver in the farmhouse by LoRa radio. The TRL 3 calculations (GGD-CAL-001) for an 18 ft (5.49 m) bin of about 88.8 t of corn give a sensor-induced moisture error of 0.23 to 0.42 points, 7.7 days of battery autonomy with no sun, and a parts cost of \$256.50 per bin. That is \$6.50 over the \$250 budget because a \$9.50 plenum probe, which measures the fan's own heat (worth about one point of moisture per degree), is now in the base kit; Amish accepted the overrun on 2026-09-25 (GGD-DDR-002). One gap remains: the 10 W panel refills the battery too slowly in winter (R8 not met).

GrainGuard

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION



Grey figure: 1.75 m person for scale

Figure 1. GrainGuard fitted to a 5.49 m (18 ft) bin, with a 1.75 m person for scale. The bin, fan and starter are existing farm equipment (grey); GrainGuard parts are colored.

■ How it works

- 1. Sense the grain.** A 6 mm galvanized wire rope hangs from the bin's center roof hanger. Six sealed pods clamped to it, 0.94 m apart, each carry a Sensirion temperature and humidity sensor behind a vapor-permeable membrane: an SHT45 (Sensirion) in the bottom and top pods, where spoilage usually starts, and an SHT40

([Sensirion](#)) in the four middle pods. Once the fan has been off for some hours, the air between the kernels comes to equilibrium with the grain, so each pod's temperature and relative humidity give the local grain temperature and, through the EMC equation, an estimate of grain moisture ([USDA ARS](#)). While the fan runs, the pods track the cooling front as it passes.

2. **Sense the air.** An SHT45 in a louvered radiation shield on the mast measures outside air. Heating does not change the air's humidity ratio, so the controller finds the plenum RH from the ambient humidity ratio and the plenum temperature, which is ambient plus the fan heat. The plenum probe (item 14), a temperature probe in the fan transition, measures the plenum temperature, so the fan heat (about 1.0 °C for a 0.40 kW fan, 0.5 to 2.7 °C across common fans, GGD-CAL-001 section A) is measured rather than assumed. The controller records the rise during each run and uses the last measured rise to decide whether to start the fan.
3. **Decide.** Every 10 min, on 30 min averages, the controller applies the rule below and asks for the fan on or off.
4. **Switch.** A 12 V signal line runs to an interposing relay kit in or beside the existing fan starter. Its optically isolated input draws 3 mA or less, and its relay, powered by its own 24 V supply, closes the starter's control circuit. A hand-off-auto switch keeps manual control, and a current transformer on one fan lead confirms that the fan runs.
5. **Report.** The controller sends readings, fan state and fan hours by LoRa, in packets of 24 bytes or less, to a small receiver in the farmhouse, which shows the bin status, logs data locally and raises heating and fault alarms.

GrainGuard: air and control flow in one example decision, 0.40 kW fan (values are estimates)

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Figure 2. Air and control flow for one example decision. Values are estimates from GGD-CAL-001 for the reference case with a 0.40 kW fan.

Control rule

The control rule was decided by Amish on 2026-09-25 (GGD-DDR-001, D3). The farmer sets the crop, the target moisture (for example 15.0 % wet basis for corn held to spring) and a mode.

- **Cool mode** (after harvest and in fall): run when the plenum air is at least 5 °C (about 10 °F) cooler than the mean grain temperature and its EMC is no more than 1.0 point above target. This follows the extension rule of running when outside air is well below grain temperature ([University of Minnesota Extension](#); [Oklahoma State University](#)), with a limit on rewetting. At the full allowance, one cooling cycle can add at most about 74 kg of water, enough to raise the bottom 0.37 m of grain by one point (GGD-CAL-001, section B).
- **Hold mode** (winter and spring): run only when the plenum-air EMC is at or below target and the air is within a set band of the grain temperature, so the fan never rewets or rewarms grain.
- **Stop when done.** The controller counts fan hours and watches the pods. When every pod has reached the new air temperature, the front has passed and the fan stops.
- **Protect the motor.** Minimum run 30 min, minimum off 15 min, no more than 4 starts per hour.
- **Fail off.** If the controller loses power or its sensor data are more than 30 min old, the relay drops out and the fan stops. The hand position of the switch always runs the fan.

The example in Figure 2 shows why the fan heat matters: outside air at 10 °C and 70 % RH has an EMC of 15.70 % and would rewet 15 % corn, but warmed 1.0 °C by a 0.40 kW fan it drops to 65.5 % RH and an EMC of 14.73 %, so the controller runs the fan. With a 1.1 kW fan the same air would reach the grain at 13.36 %.

■ Main components

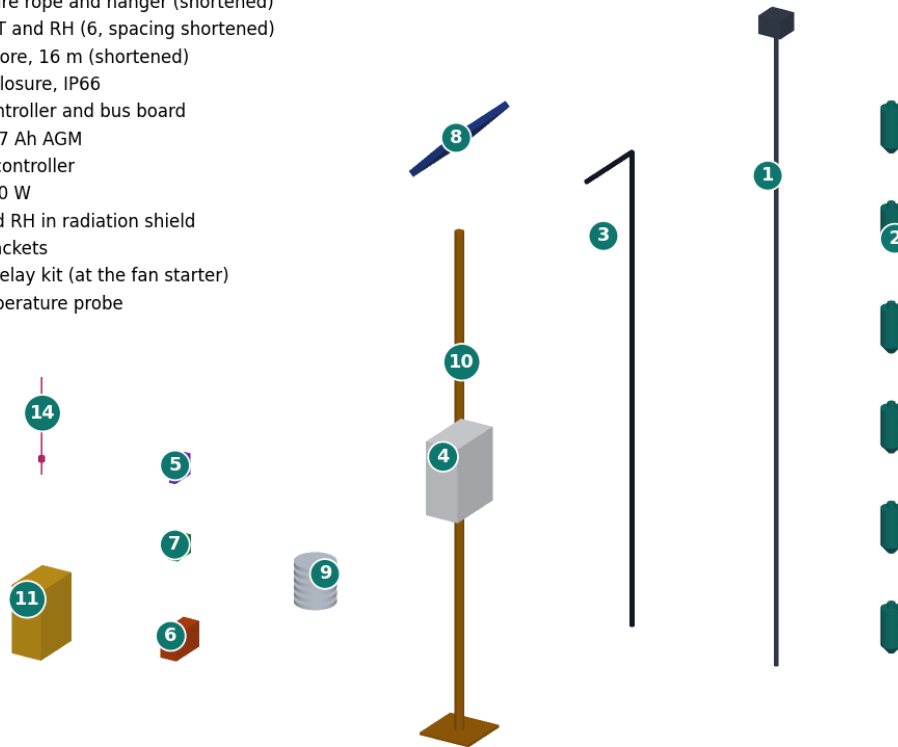
Numbers match the exploded view (Figure 3), drawing GGD-DWG-001 and `bom/bom.csv`.

#	Component	Choice	Notes
1	Suspension wire rope and hanger	6 mm galvanized 7x19 rope, 6.6 m hung, thimble, clips, shackle	Hangs from the bin maker's rated center hanger only
2	Sensor pods (6)	2a: SHT45 (bottom and top, two); 2b: SHT40 (middle four); PTFE membrane, bus microcontroller, RS-485, potted pod 76 mm by 140 mm	0.94 m apart; bottom pod 0.25 m above the floor, top pod 0.25 m below a level surface
3	Bus cable	4-core shielded UV-rated cable, 16 m, 12 V and RS-485	Down the rope, out the peak cap, over the roof and down the wall; route 14.6 m
4	Controller enclosure	IP66 polycarbonate, about 280 x 230 x 130 mm	On the mast, shaded side of the bin
5	LoRa microcontroller and bus board	nRF52840 plus SX1262 class module, RS-485 transceiver, buck regulator	915 MHz in the Americas
6	Battery	12 V 7 Ah AGM lead-acid	Accepts charge below 0 °C; capacity open (GGD-DDR-001, 02)
7	Solar charge controller	12 V PWM, temperature compensation clamped at 15.0 V, low-voltage disconnect, 6 mA or less self-use	Clamp keeps the system at 15 V or less (R12)
8	Solar panel	10 W, tilted 45 degrees	On top of the mast
9	Ambient sensor	SHT45 in a louvered radiation shield on a 330 mm arm	1.8 m above the pad, away from the bin wall's reflected heat
10	Mast and brackets	DN25 (33.7 x 3.2 mm) galvanized pipe, 2.3 m, base plate on the pad, one stay to the bin	No drilling of bin sheets
11	Interposing relay kit	DIN 24 V supply, relay with optically isolated 12 V input of 3 mA or less, hand-off-auto switch, current transformer	Only mains-connected item; licensed electrician installs
12	Farmhouse receiver	ESP32 plus LoRa with display and Wi-Fi	One per farm, costed per farm; not shown in the model
13	Hardware and consumables	Ties, anchors, sealant, conformal coating	Not shown
14	Plenum temperature probe	DS18B20 probe (± 0.5 °C) in the fan transition, downstream of the fan	In the base kit (GGD-DDR-002); measures the fan heat for R4

GrainGuard: exploded view

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION

- 1 Suspension wire rope and hanger (shortened)
- 2 Sensor pods, T and RH (6, spacing shortened)
- 3 Bus cable, 4-core, 16 m (shortened)
- 4 Controller enclosure, IP66
- 5 LoRa microcontroller and bus board
- 6 Battery, 12 V 7 Ah AGM
- 7 Solar charge controller
- 8 Solar panel, 10 W
- 9 Ambient T and RH in radiation shield
- 10 Mast and brackets
- 11 Interposing relay kit (at the fan starter)
- 14 Plenum temperature probe



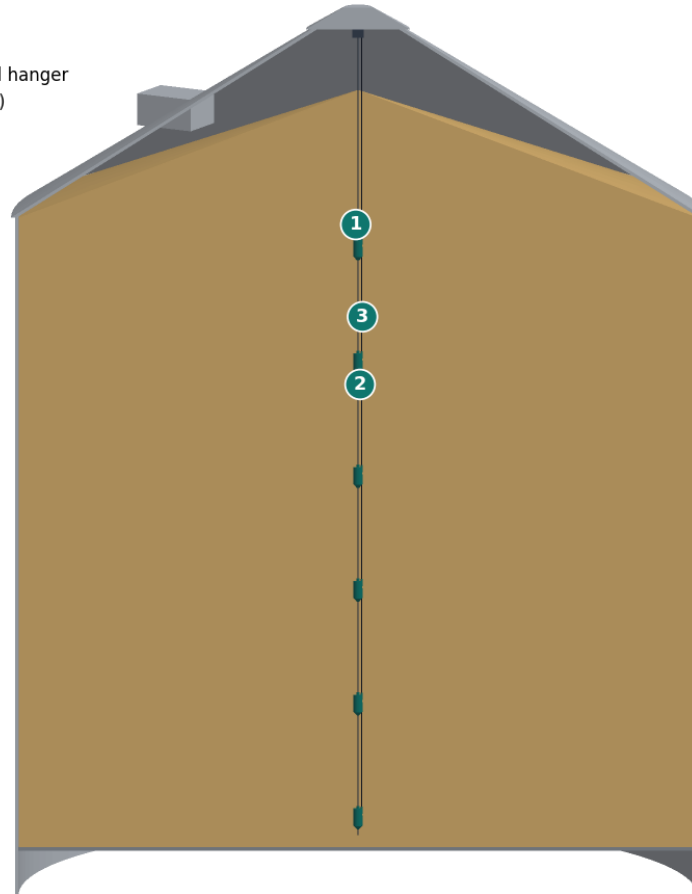
Numbers match bom/bom.csv. Rope, pods and cable shortened; not to scale. Bin, grain, fan and starter not shown.

Figure 3. Exploded view with numbered callouts matching the BOM. The rope, pods and cable are shortened and the view is not to scale.

GrainGuard: cutaway on the bin axis

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION

- 1 Suspension wire rope and hanger
- 2 Sensor pods, T and RH (6)
- 3 Bus cable (in-bin run)



Six pods 940 mm apart hang from the roof peak through 5.2 m of grain. Grain is cut; pods are not.

Figure 4. Cutaway on the bin axis showing the sensor cable hanging from the roof peak through 5.2 m of grain.

■ Key numbers

All numbers below come from GGD-CAL-001, which also gives the status of every requirement. Tags in brackets refer to lines of `docs/04-calcs/sizing.py`.

Table 1. Key numbers for the reference case.

Quantity	TRL 3 value	Requirement
Grain held, level to the eave	123.1 m ³ , 3,493 bu, 88.8 t of corn [A2]	
Airflow at 0.2 cfm/bu; static pressure	0.330 m ³ /s (699 cfm); 139 Pa (0.56 in wc) [A3], [A4]	
Fan heat rise	1.0 °C at 0.40 kW; 0.5 to 2.7 °C for 0.2 to 1.1 kW [A7]	Measured by item 14
Cooling front time	75 to 119 h of fan time [A8]	
Plenum EMC change per °C of fan heat	0.97 points [B1]	
Plenum EMC uncertainty with the probe	about ±0.50 points (±0.51 °C on the fan heat) [B10]	R4 met
Sensor-induced EMC error, worst case 20 % to 75 % RH	0.23 points (SHT45), 0.42 points (SHT40) [B5]	R2 at risk
Hot spot coverage, one center cable	3.3 % of the cross-section [C2]	R6 at risk
Daily energy, fan continuous	3.28 Wh [D3]	
Autonomy with no sun at -20 °C, fan continuous	7.7 days [D5]	R8 autonomy met
Refill from 50 % at 1.5 winter peak sun hours	7.3 days [D6]	R8 not met
Radio margin at 1 km past one building	17.6 dB [E3]	R7 met
Cable pull-down estimate; rope factor on 2.5 kN	2.08 kN; 8.0 [F2], [F3]	R10 rope met; hanger per bin
Per-bin kit with the probe; receiver per farm	\$256.50; \$22.00 [H1], [H2]	R13 not met, \$6.50 overrun accepted

The fan heat was the largest uncertainty at TRL 3: an error of 1 °C in an assumed value shifts the decision by about one point of EMC, more than the whole sensor error. The plenum probe measures it for \$9.50 and cuts that error to about ±0.5 points.

■ Key design choices

Every choice below was decided by Amish on 2026-09-25 by adopting the TRL 2 recommendations (GGD-DDR-001) and the TRL 3 recommendations (GGD-DDR-002).

- **RH-based moisture sensing rather than capacitance probes** (D4). Interstitial RH with an EMC equation is cheap and has published accuracy data; its weakness is wet grain above about 80 % RH and the need for crop-specific constants.
- **One center cable with six pods** (D5), enough for a 5.5 m bin at this price; larger bins need more cables.
- **RS-485 pod bus with a small microcontroller in each pod** (D6). The SHT4x sensors have a fixed I²C address and I²C does not suit 15 m of cable.
- **Solar 12 V controller with an electrician-installed relay kit** (D7). Keeps mains out of the GrainGuard box.

- **AGM battery rather than lithium iron phosphate** (D8). AGM accepts charge below freezing; LiFePO₄ cells generally must not be charged below 0 °C without a heater.
- **Plenum sensing** (GGD-DDR-001 D9; GGD-DDR-002). The lowest-cost form, a temperature-only probe, does not fit in \$250, but Amish adopted it into the base kit and accepted the \$6.50 overrun, since no other \$9.50 buys as much decision accuracy.
- **Control rule, modes and default targets** as set out above (D3).
- **Headspace CO₂ sensor as an option**, not in the base kit (D10).
- **Budget** (D1): \$250 per bin with the farmhouse receiver costed per farm, reached by fitting SHT40 sensors in the four middle pods and a smaller enclosure (\$247.00); with the plenum probe the kit is \$256.50, an overrun accepted under GGD-DDR-002.
- **Relay input of 3 mA or less and charging clamped at 15.0 V**, set in GGD-CAL-001 to meet R8 autonomy and R12 at no cost (GGD-DDR-002).

■ Safety

Safety: Grain bins kill people. GrainGuard is designed so that no one needs to enter a bin holding grain, but installing the cable still means roof work and entry into an empty bin, and the controller starts a fan and a motor automatically. Treat each of these as a hazard at every stage.

- **Engulfment and entrapment.** Never enter a bin holding grain to install or service GrainGuard. Install the cable only with the bin empty, unloading equipment locked out, a confined-space entry procedure, and a trained spotter outside. Flowing grain can bury a person in seconds.
- **Falls.** The cable is fed through the roof manhole or peak cap. Use the bin's ladder cage and roof rail with fall protection; do not work on a wet, icy or windy roof.
- **Automatic fan start.** The fan can start at any time in automatic mode. Mark the fan and starter "Starts automatically", lock out at the disconnect before touching the fan, transition or plenum, and never rely on GrainGuard being "off" for safety. Keep guards on the fan inlet.
- **Mains voltage.** The fan starter carries 230 V single-phase or 208 V to 480 V three-phase. Only a licensed electrician installs the relay kit (item 11), with isolation of at least 2.5 kV between the 12 V input and the relay contacts. GrainGuard's own box, cable and pods are 12 V DC.
- **Roof load.** Grain drags on the cable during unloading. Hang the rope only from a hanger the bin maker rates for cable loads; an unrated roof can buckle. Unload from the center first, as the bin maker requires.
- **Lightning and surges.** A tall steel bin attracts lightning, and the cable enters from the roof. Bond the rope and cable shield to the bin, add surge protection on the bus at the controller, and keep the signal cable to the starter short.
- **Fumigants.** Phosphine is highly toxic and corrodes copper and electronics ([FAO fumigation manual](#)). Only certified applicators fumigate. GrainGuard does not measure phosphine and must not be used to decide when a bin is safe to enter.
- **Grain dust.** Dust in the headspace can burn or explode. The pods run at 12 V and a few milliamps, but the design has not been assessed against hazardous-location rules; keep all connections outside the bin sealed and never open pods inside a dusty bin.

- **Plenum probe.** Fitting the probe means drilling one 12 mm hole for a gland in the fan transition. Lock out the fan at the disconnect first, keep hands out of the transition, and fit the probe downstream of the fan, never near the impeller.
- **Battery.** The 12 V AGM battery can deliver high short-circuit current and vents hydrogen if overcharged. Fuse it at the terminal and use a temperature-compensated charger with its voltage clamped at 15.0 V. A lead-acid battery left partly discharged can freeze and crack at about -25 °C.

■ Open questions

- Battery and panel capacity to meet the recovery half of R8: a 20 W panel, a relaxed target, or accepting the miss (GGD-DDR-001, O2). Proposed, awaiting Amish.
- First host farm and electrician for a co-design visit (GGD-DDR-001, O1). Proposed, awaiting Amish.
- Pitch wording against the cool-mode rewet bound: keep "without rewetting it", say only "cool it or dry it", or cut the cool-mode allowance to zero (GGD-DDR-002, O4). No recommendation; proposed, awaiting Amish.
- Confirm the control rule's defaults and target moisture values with an extension specialist and a host farmer.
- How long interstitial air takes to reach equilibrium after the fan stops, so the controller knows when a moisture reading is valid.
- Protect pods and connectors against phosphine (conformal coating, sealed connectors, or pods removed before fumigation).
- Low-voltage disconnect setting that keeps the AGM battery from freezing at -30 °C.
- Which bin makers rate their roof hangers for cable loads.
- LoRa coverage on a real farm with the bin in the path.

Concept media: [blueprint sheet](#), [interactive 3D model](#). General arrangement: [GGD-DWG-001](#).